

Headline Writing

REGION MEET • 2022



You are a copy editor for the Leaguetown **Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School.

Write the headline assigned for each of the given six stories. Use the following system: all upper and lower case letters, spaces, punctuation marks and symbols count as 1. Capitalize the first letter of the first word of each headline. You may use either upstyle (capitalizing the first letter of every word) or downstyle (capitalizing the first letter of the first word and the first letter of proper nouns only thereafter). Remember that main headlines belong on the top line and secondary headlines belong under the main headline. You have **30 minutes**.

Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry.

Story 1 — Write: 1-line main headline counting 10-16 and a 2-line secondary headline with each line counting 18-24

Junior quarterback Carson Royale admits cheerleading is more dangerous than football.

At least it has been for him.

At the annual powder puff football game, Carson was cheering for the junior team when he attempted a cartwheel and sprained his ankle.

"I am so embarrassed," he said. "I played varsity football for two years and never had a single injury."

Luckily, Carson didn't break anything.

"I have to wear a boot for six weeks," he said. "The cheerleaders already decorated it. They are getting a real kick out of this."

Football coach Randall Oats said next year he will ban his players from attempting any cheerleading stunts.

"At least Carson will be healed before we start our summer training," Oats said.

Story 2 — Write: 1-line main headline counting 12-18 and a 1-line secondary headline counting 22-28

The school is getting less trashy every day.

In March, the cafeteria began piloting a composting program where nearly every lunch item — from the flatware to the trays — is composted.

"We wanted to align with the city's zero waste goal to re-circularize [e.g. recycle, compost, share] over 70% of our surplus and waste by 2040," Superintendent Murray Pulliam said. "We started in the cafeteria because that is where so much of our waste comes from."

Cafeteria manager Abby Johnston said she and her staff were happy to pilot the program.

"Less waste means a better tomorrow," she said. "It's taken a little while for students to understand the different waste cans, but they are getting the hang of it."

The cafeteria now has both compost cans and regular trash cans for items students bring from home.

Story 3 — Write: 3-line headline with each line counting 12-18

To attract more substitute teachers, the district will increase their pay from \$100 a day to \$150 a day starting next school year.

"We've been about 10 substitutes short each day this year," Superintendent Murray Pulliam said. "When we reached out to our former substitutes who were no longer subbing, most said they stopped because the pay was too low."

English teacher Gennifer Flour said she hopes the pay increase will entice more people to sub.

"I've had to give up my conference period a lot this year to cover other classes," she said. "The district pays us to do that, but not having a conference period makes my job a lot more difficult."

Parent Rand Gillian, who substituted several times this year, said the pay increase is overdue.

"Other districts pay more than Leaguetown," he said. "This will definitely help."

Story 4 — Write: 2-line headline with each line counting 20-26

After a string of injuries, the softball team finally has all of its players back, just in time for the first round of the playoffs. The team will play Center High School at 7 p.m. Tuesday at home.

“This will be our first game all season with all of our players healthy,” head coach Toni Castillo said. “It’s been a rough season, but the girls never gave up.”

Starting pitcher senior Heather Thomas was out for three weeks with a sprained knee.

“Sitting out six games was the hardest thing I’ve ever done,” she said. “But Chastity Lassiter [a junior] stepped up and helped get the wins for the team. She even pitched a no-hitter against Southside.”

Castillo said four junior varsity players were moved to varsity.

“Those girls played like they had been on varsity all year,” she said. “They will join us in the playoffs, and they will play.”

Last year, the softball team was knocked out in the second round of the playoffs.

“Our team is stronger this year, especially with everyone back,” Thomas said. “We are on our way to State.”

Story 5 — Write: 1-line headline counting 26-32

The marching band will look a little different on the football field next fall. After 10 years, the band is getting new uniforms.

“There are some dramatic changes from what we’ve had in the past,” band director Whit Hanson said. “The new uniforms are lighter and more modern.”

The uniforms also will be more colorful, Hanson said.

“The old uniforms were mostly black with red lines,” he said. “The new ones highlight the school colors — red and blue. We will look so much brighter and dynamic on the field.”

Drum major and junior Sun Li said she loves the new design and hopes the uniforms arrive in August.

“We’ve seen pictures,” she said. “I can’t wait to wear them. Our current uniforms are so old and so hot. It was hard to march in them when it was 100 degrees outside. We all were so sweaty.”

Story 6 — Write: 1-line main headline counting 16-22 and a 1-line secondary headline counting 26-32

Science teacher Vic Fritzell likes hot food.

The hotter the better.

And he’s got more than 5,000 ways to make his food blazing hot.

Fritzell has the largest collection of hot sauces in North America.

“I started collecting hot sauces when I was in college, and pretty soon it became my obsession,” he said. “Now, 25 years later, I have an entire room in my house dedicated to hot sauce.”

Fritzell recently acquired a bottle of Blair’s 16 Million Reserve, supposedly the hottest hot sauce on the planet.

“I’ve tried every one of my hot sauces, and Blair’s is definitely the hottest,” he said. “It felt like my tongue was on fire.”

Last week, a reporter from The New York Times interviewed him for a feature story.

“I guess I’m getting my 15 minutes of fame,” he said. “I didn’t start collecting hot sauces to be famous. I collected them because I love spicy food, and I wanted variety.”

Fritzell said his favorite hot sauce is Black Mamba 6 Hot Sauce by Get Bitten. The “six” in the name refers to the fact that this sauce is made with an extract that has 6 million Scovilles (the hot sauce rating system). A typical medium salsa from a grocery store usually tops out with a 4,000 Scoville rating.

“Black Mamba definitely has plenty of heat, but it also has plenty of flavor, too,” he said.

Junior Derrek Brown said he’s tried some of the hot sauces Fritzell brings with his lunches.

“A couple of us figured we could handle some of his weaker hot sauces,” Brown said. “We couldn’t. Two of the guys threw up, and my mouth burned for the rest of the day.”

Contestant's Number _____

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Headline Writing Entry Sheet

All letters (upper and lower case), numbers, punctuation marks, symbols and spaces count as one (1). Place one letter or other unit in the appropriate spaces below. Remember to leave spaces between words. Note that the number of lines you are given on this sheet corresponds to the number of lines required for each headline. **Write your number on the upper right-hand corner of this sheet.**

■ Headline Number 1

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

main headline

secondary headline

■ Headline Number 2

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

main headline

secondary headline

■ Headline Number 3

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

Contestant's Number _____

■ Headline Number 4

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30	31	32

■ Headline Number 5

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30	31	32

■ Headline Number 6

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30	31	32

main headline

secondary headline

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST!

REGION • 2022

HEADLINE WRITING CONTEST TIPS AND SAMPLES

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during critique/judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judges.

1. Headline writing is different than the other contests. It is suggested you pace yourself. You have about 5 minutes for each headline. Don't watch the clock, but be aware of the time you are taking to complete a headline. It is better to have four or five good headlines rather than six mediocre ones.
2. Highlight or underline important words in the story. Then write a sentence based on those highlighted/underlined words.
3. After you have your first sentence, go back and change or delete words. If you have a multi-line headline, separate the lines at a recommended area. This means you should not split phrases or ideas. Make sure all types of phrases — noun, verb, adverb, adjective and prepositional phrases especially — are on the same line. Play with words until the headline fits. It may be necessary to re-write the headline one or more times or to take a different approach before you get the key idea. Eliminate all unnecessary words such as article adjectives (a, an, the). In many cases, a comma can substitute for the word "and."
4. You may use a thesaurus or dictionary, either printed or electronic. You may write in block letters. You should not be penalized for inconsistency in upstyle or downstyle.
5. Make sure you are within the prescribed count. Individual headlines that are under or over the count are disqualified.
6. Use active verbs in either present, future or present perfect tense. Make sure your headline matches the tone of the story. If it is a fun story, write a fun headline; if it is a serious story, write a serious headline.
7. Never sacrifice accuracy for creativity or cuteness.
8. Normally, the main headline is used to grab the reader's attention. It is not necessary, although it is possible, to have a verb in the main headline when you have a secondary headline. The secondary headline should do one of two things: emphasize the significant aspects of the story or the unusual. The main headline does not require a verb. The secondary headline does.
9. The following are additional basic headline rules for you to follow:
 - avoid starting the headline with a verb
 - always use single quotes
 - avoid using the same word twice in a headline
 - use active verbs, not passive verbs
 - try to write in present or future tense
 - avoid unfamiliar abbreviations
 - do not end the headline with a period
 - avoid spelling out numbers (use numerals - 1, 20, etc.)

★ STORY #1

A Royale pain	13
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★ STORY #2

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★ STORY #6

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